back: he is two-time winner of the ESL India Premiership and has won the AIFF eFootball Challenge, Esportz Premiership India and Nostra Gaming competitions. Unlike other Asian Games-bound athletes like Biswas and Bata, Singh benefits from playing a game whose international popularity means greater exposure and a bigger prize pool. Singh enjoys watching football (he's a Chelsea supporter) and playing the sport, though his talent on the console far outstrips that on a football field. "It is a very fast game. You need good knowledge and reflexes are important," he says. "Every year, FIFA has a new version, so you have to constantly adapt." Singh's prowess has ensured India the sixth rank in FIFA Esports. He recently topped the South Asia seeding event and guaranteed a favourable seeding for the 19th Asian Games. Should one fancy India's chances at the Games? "Obviously," says Singh. "But anything can happen. We won't get ahead of ourselves."

## REALITY CHECKS

Not every Esports athlete in the Indian team expects a full-time career in gaming. Shubham Goli from Solapur, a key member of the bronze-winning Dota team in Birmingham, feels it's time to get a job. "There are not enough Dota teams in India to upgrade my skills," says the 25-year-old. "Why would [any company] hire me if I tell them how much time I put into gaming?" Currently pursuing a diploma in advanced computing from Pune, Goli is prepping both for his exams (due in August) and the Asian Games.

Animesh Agarwal believes one way to ensure the Indian gaming ecosystem doesn't lose promising talent is greater investment through organisation of tournaments and events by 'publishers' (firms that market or 'publish' games), brand collaborations and, vitally, development of dedicated gaming servers. Though PC games lag behind mobile games in India, Valorant, a PC gaming title, has flourished due to its publisher Riot Games's capitalising on its potential, he points out. "Publishers like Riot and Krafton have forged partnerships with endemic and non-endemic brands (those related to Esports and those from other industries)," says Agarwal. "It is crucial for publishers [of LoL, Dota and Street Fighter] to focus on building a sustainable model that enables a player base to grow and thrive in India." If there are more tournaments and investment in PC gaming, viewership will grow, allowing Esports to flourish as a whole.

For now, the Asian Games Esports contingent is eager to seize their opportunity. Prajapati is as excited as a fanboy at the prospect of facing Street Fighter stars Gamer B from Chinese Taipei and Margo from Japan. "I have strategies to tackle them...I know their moves," he says. "They don't know anything about me. So I am the underdog." In sports, you never underestimate an underdog. Even if the sport is a video game. ■

MANDAR DEODHAR




**DARSHAN BATA**
**AGE: 29**
**Stock market trader**
**PLAYING COMPETITIVELY SINCE: 2013**
**GAME: Captain of India's Dota 2 team at the Asian Games**

**2.5**
**MILLION**
PROJECTED NO. OF GAMERS IN INDIA BY THE END OF 2023

**$1.4**
**BILLION**
(OR Rs 11,487 CRORE) PROJECTED PLAYER SPEND TO BE GENERATED BY INDIA'S PC AND MOBILE GAME MARKETS IN 2026